live with each other's fantasies and refrain from interpreting them as a *casus belli.* Living side by side over time will dull the intensity of the fantasy on both sides. To truly adopt the process I describe here, it is essential that we have leaders of the stature of Begin and Sadat or Rabin and Hussein.

The "Arab Spring" in the Middle East has created instability in this region of a kind that we have not seen since the end of the First World War. The factor that distinguishes this instability more than anything else is the religious component, which has brought the world back to the era of the "clash of civilizations." The reader may well ask, "How can a Middle East in such a state of chaos move forward with an initiative for a peace agreement?" Well, within this chaos one can identify a series of variables, some necessary and others desirable, around which one can sketch a geopolitical and strategic architecture that is worthy of examination.

At the implementation level, there is no doubt that the initiative will require American involvement, and perhaps even a deep commitment. Such involvement is likely to be achieved only after the next US presidents are convinced that both the Israeli and the Arab sides are genuinely willing to accept the principles outlined in the initiative. This persuasion would be achieved not by public pronouncements, but, at least in the early stages, through secret contacts.

A necessary condition for the advancement of the initiative is the conviction of the parties, and especially of their leaders, that its implementation and success will create a win-win situation. Obviously, if any party remains unconvinced that it stands to profit from the initiative, its chances of success will be greatly reduced. I believe that all of the parties involved could benefit from the Saudi Initiative, as I explain in detail below.

The United States

The United States' involvement in resolving the Arab-Israeli conflict would make it a key partner in the creation of a Middle East characterized by peace development, in the weakening of radical Islamic groups, and in the bringing about of calm in the entire Islamic world.